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Snow Tsunami and Earthquake in Kashmir

One of the worst natural disasters in recent years struck Kashmir in February 2005, soon after I became the army chief. Two spells of unprecedented heavy snowfall and inclement weather, the first being around 6 February and the second ten days later, brought Jammu and Kashmir to a standstill for almost one month. Nature does not differentiate between man-made boundaries, and hence the Pakistani side of the LoC was equally badly affected. Large areas were cut off, rendering even assessment of the damage and destruction impossible. Heavy accumulation of snow on the hill slopes triggered a series of avalanches and landslides, which buried numerous villages, crippled electricity and water supplies and blocked most roads and airfields. The army, by virtue of its extensive grid deployment in far-flung areas, was able to respond quickly and spearhead the rescue and relief effort. I gave orders to provide assistance without waiting for formal or written requisition from the state government. Rescue columns of the army saved the lives of sixty-nine people. Food and medical assistance was provided to about 1800 people. Besides that, clothing, blankets and tents were made available to hundreds of marooned passengers and destitute villagers who would otherwise have frozen to death. We recovered 208 bodies buried under the snow. As a humanitarian gesture, I ordered the release of 70 per cent of our war reserves of petrol, diesel and rations to provide succour to the people.

The main artery connecting Jammu with Srinagar remained cut off till 1 March 2005, when the border roads and the army finally cleared it. During this period, I accompanied Defence Minister Pranab Mukherjee to the state for an aerial survey of the worst-hit